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Migration and Social Mobility: South East England as an Escalator Region

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FIELDING A. J. (1992) Migration and social mobility: South East England as an escalator region, *Reg. Studies* 26, 1–15. This paper uses data from the OPCS Longitudinal Study and the National Health Service Central Register to examine the contention that the South East region of England acts as a kind of 'upward social class escalator' within the British urban and regional system. To establish that this is so it is shown firstly, that the South East attracts to itself through inter-regional migration a more than proportional share of the potentially upwardly mobile young adults; secondly, that it promotes these young people along with its own young adults at rates which are higher than elsewhere in the country; and finally, that a significant proportion of those who achieve these higher levels of status and pay then 'step off' the escalator. They do this by migrating away from the South East at later stages of their working lives and at or near to retirement. The analysis is then extended in two respects. Firstly, the general connections between inter-regional migration and occupational class mobility are examined. It is shown that the association between the two is strongly positive, and that migration to the South East seems to be one of the most important factors favouring upward social mobility. Secondly, and by way of qualification to what has gone before, the complexities of the South East's migration situation are explored more fully to show that, although very useful, the escalator metaphor has its limitations and cannot be relied upon to illuminate all aspects of the migration flows to and from the region.

Social mobility South East Migration Longitudinal Study

FIELDING A. J. (1992) La migration et la mobilité sociale: le Sud-Est d'Angleterre comme escalier roulant régional, *Reg. Studies* 26, 1–15. Cet article se sert des données provenant de l'enquête longitudinale de l'OPCS et du registre central de la Sécurité Sociale afin d'examiner l'affirmation suivante: au sein du système urbano-régional britannique le Sud-Est du Royaume-Uni constitue 'un escalier roulant' des classes sociales qui monte. Afin de le confirmer on démontre dans un premier temps que le Sud-Est attire à partir de la migration interrégionale une part disproportionnée des jeunes susceptibles d'une ascension sociale; dans un deuxième temps que de telles jeunes ainsi que les jeunes indigènes se voient donner de l'avancement plus tôt par rapport au reste du pays; et pour terminer qu'une proportion non-négligeable de ceux qui atteignent ces niveaux supérieurs de standing et de traitement descendent ensuite de 'l'escalier'. Cela se passe à partir d'une migration en provenance du Sud-Est à des étapes ultérieures de leur vie active et au moment de la retraite. L'analyse se voit développer sous deux optiques. En premier on examine les rapports généraux entre la migration interrégionale et la mobilité socio-professionnelle. On démontre que le rapport entre ces deux variables s'avère très positif et que la migration à destination du Sud-Est semble être un des facteurs explicatifs les plus importants en faveur de la mobilité sociale. En deuxième, et pour soutenir cet argument-là, on approfondit les complexités de cette migration pour démontrer que bien qu'elle soit très utile, cette image d'un escalier roulant a ses limites dans la mesure où on ne peut pas y compter pour illustrer sous tous leurs angles les flux migratoires à destination de et en provenance de la région.

Mobilité sociale Sud-Est Migration
Etude longitudinale

FIELDING A. J. (1992) Wanderung und gesellschaftliche Mobilität: Südostengland als Rolltreppe gebiet, *Reg. Studies* 26, 1–15. Dieser Aufsatz benutzt Daten der Längsstudie des Office of Population Census and Surveys (OPCS) und des Zentralregisters der staatlichen Gesundheitsfürsorge (NHS) zur Untersuchung der Behauptung, dass der Südosten Englands im städtischen und regionalen System des Landes als eine Art aufsteigender 'Rolltreppe sozialer Klassen' wirkt. Um dies zu bestätigen, wird zunächst gezeigt, dass der Südosten durch interregionale Wanderung mehr als seinen verhältnismässigen Anteil potentiell aufsteigender junger Leute anzieht; sodann, dass diese jungen Leute dort wie die im Südosten Ansässigen schneller als sonst irgendwo im Lande befördert werden, und schliesslich, dass eine bedeutende Anzahl derer, die diese hohen Status- und Gehaltsstufen erreichen, dann von der Rolltreppe 'abspringen', indem sie in den späteren Jahren ihres Arbeitslebens und bei oder kurz vor ihrer Pensionierung den Südosten verlassen. Die Analyse wird dann in zweifacher Hinsicht ausgedehnt: erstens auf die Untersuchung allgemeiner Verknüpfungen zwischen interregionaler Wanderung und Beweglichkeit von Beschäftigungsgruppen, wobei sich die Verbindung zwischen beiden als äusserst positiv erweist, und zweitens, und zugleich zur Qualifizierung des oben Gesagten, auf eine tiefer schürfende Untersuchung der Verflechtungen in der Wanderungslage des Südostens, um zu zeigen, dass die Rolltreppe-metaphor, obschon nützlich, doch ihre Grenzen hat und sich nicht unbedingt zur Erläuterung aller Aspekte der Wanderströmungen zu und aus der Region verwenden lässt.

Gesellschaftliche Beweglichkeit Südosten
Wanderung Längsstudie

INTRODUCTION: LOCATION AND LIFE CHANGES

It is a disconcerting fact about the world in which we live that the chance circumstances of one's birth determine to a considerable extent the likelihood that one will enjoy a full and rewarding life. Someone born in Africa or South Asia will have a life expectancy which is only just over half that of a person born in Western Europe, and during that short life his or her living standard will be only one twenty-fifth of that of the average Western European (KIDRON and SEGAL, 1980, maps 23 and 45). In the face of such poverty many young people have left their homes in Third World countries and migrated to high income countries. With increasing seriousness, however, the governments of Western European countries have acted to restrict these migrations. They have done so on the basis of a reasonable expectation that such migrations have a momentum of their own which, once established, is difficult to check. They also know that the potential supply of such migrants is, for all intents and purposes, unlimited. Their fears of the political consequences of mass immigration have been further increased since 1989 by the events in Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union.

These governments can do much individually and collectively to restrict international mass migration, but they cannot control in the same way the migration of people within their own countries. To attempt to do so would be to confront deeply-held assumptions about what being a citizen of such a country entails. So within the countries of Western Europe, and increasingly between the member countries of the European Community, there is a legally unfettered migration of people from one region to another, many of them seeking through this migration to enhance their life chances.

This paper is about such migrations in Britain, and about the role that the South East region (London's metropolitan city region) plays in an inter-regional migration system linked to intra-generational social mobility. It has three main sections and a conclusion. The first section describes the notion of an escalator region, and establishes the criteria which would need to be met before a region could be properly identified as an escalator region. The second section examines the evidence to see if the South East can indeed be classified as an escalator region. It has four sub-sections. The first is concerned with the general relationship between social mobility and geographical mobility. Does such a relationship exist, and if so, what form does it take? The second sub-section examines the evidence relating to the South East region's ability to attract a disproportionate share of the potentially upwardly mobile young people. The third sub-section discusses evidence relating to the

rates of social promotion in the South East. Do people stand a better chance of achieving social promotion in the South East region than elsewhere in the country? The final sub-section examines evidence that people 'step off' the escalator at the mid- or late-career stages of their lives by migrating away from the region. Having established that the South East region does indeed meet the requirements set out in section one, and can reasonably be regarded as an escalator region, the third and final empirical section of the paper investigates the arguments which force us to qualify this view. They include the importance of international migration in service class recruitment in the South East, the effects of the size and complexity of the South East's labour market on migration rates to and from the region, and the fact that the South East gains migrants at both ends of the social class spectrum. The short conclusion discusses the implications of this research for our understanding of the links between class and region—between society and space.

The empirical analyses reported in this paper are based upon two large datasets: the Office of Population Censuses and Surveys' (OPCS) Longitudinal Study (LS), and the National Health Service Central Register (NHSCR). The LS is ideally suited to studies of the relationships between social and geographical mobility. It consists of about 500,000 matched census records from the 1971 and 1981 censuses (soon to be extended to the 1991 census). We know, therefore, what individuals' class positions and geographical locations were at two points in time, ten years apart. This allows us to look at the social mobility of the non-migrants and of the migrants, and even of the migrants to and from a specific region (in this case South East England). It also allows us to investigate which of the attributes of an individual at time t , and which of the changes in attributes between t and $t+1$ (for example, change in region of residence) are most closely associated with social promotion. Thus, for the first time in Britain, we have an aggregate dataset which offers us the opportunity to 'unpack' these important connections between migration and social change. The great drawback with this data, of course, is that it refers to the 1970s rather than the 1980s. It is the confident belief of this author, however, that the LS results for 1981–91 will confirm the results presented here; indeed there are reasons for thinking that the South East region was likely to be rather *more* significant in promoting upward social mobility in the 1980s than in the 1970s. A second disadvantage of the LS is that the transitions of interest take place over a ten-year period. This implies that some of the associations will not coincide temporally, and that the transitions will occur in rather different demographic and economic contexts depending on their position within the decade. The LS has until now been most actively

used by medical sociologists, but its value in migration analysis is beginning to be realized (GRUNDY, 1986; STUART, 1989; HAMNETT, 1990).

The NHSCR migration data, based upon doctor re-registrations, is far less helpful when it comes to the social composition of migration streams but, on the other hand, it has much greater spatial and temporal detail than the LS, and it is the only source of good up-to-date information on migration flows in Britain. It can, furthermore, be disaggregated by age and sex. The NHSCR migration data is routinely used in the production of local population estimates and projections, and has for a long time been the basis of non-census-based academic research on migration in Britain (OGILVY, 1982; STILLWELL *et al.*, 1992). Used together, the NHSCR and LS represent a powerful resource for analyses of migration processes in Britain.

What is so disappointing about previous work on migration to and from the South East region is its lack of concern for the social mobility aspects of the movement. This is true both for the regional science/econometric literature and for the recent debates about the relationships between geographical mobility and the nature of regional housing and labour markets. However, before we begin to engage in our analysis of the connections between social and geographical mobility, we need to identify the principal research issue for this study, that is, the relevance and usefulness of the concept of an escalator region.

THE CONCEPT OF AN ESCALATOR REGION

For what conceivable purpose might one wish to liken a region to a moving staircase? The basic reason is that people possessing the same qualifications and achieving the same levels of work performance nevertheless experience quite different occupational class trajectories in different places. We are probably all familiar with this situation as it affects young people entering the labour market. Youth unemployment rates during the 1980s were particularly high in the major industrial conurbations of northern and western Britain and in the West Midlands. They were lowest in the towns and rural areas around London, and in the free-standing cities of southern England. ASHTON *et al.*, 1987, for example, show that a school-leaver in St Albans (in the South East region) had a one-in-forty chance of failing to obtain employment in 1983, whereas for a school-leaver in Sunderland (in the Northern region) the ratio was between one-in-three and one-in-four. Ashton *et al.* argue that labour market context not only affects the chances of getting a job, but also the type of job obtained, the likelihood of job change, the length of period of unemployment and work attitudes—all of

which favoured the inhabitants of their town in the South East region over that in the Northern region. They also found that these differences were not due to social class contrasts between the two places: working class young people in St Albans had distinctly better life chances than those in Sunderland. A related perspective on this phenomenon comes from the work of PECK and HAUGHTON, 1987. They describe the 'bumping down' process in northern cities whereby school-leavers lower their sights in the face of high levels of unemployment, and accept jobs which do not use their abilities to the full. Thus, in the same way as the regional context seems to move the individual upwards in the South East, it seems to move the individual downwards in the north and west.

The concept of the escalator region, however, is not confined to the differential potential for occupational class advancement in different regions. It is far more dynamic than this. It incorporates the idea that by migrating from one region to another, individuals 'step off' one escalator and 'step onto' another. From this perspective, the key to social promotion for the young and the ambitious is to combine an energetic pursuit of career advancement within their fields of expertise with a *judicious use of spatial differences*. In Britain this strategy of combining individual improvement with spatial manoeuvring also characterizes housing 'careers'; household wealth has been enhanced for many people through an active use of the fiscally-privileged owner occupation housing market (riding the mortgage escalator). The key to success is to purchase housing in those locations, both locally and regionally, where land and house prices are set to rise, and to avoid those places where they are likely to fall. Since regional housing markets are, of course, intimately related to regional labour markets, it tends to be the same regions which experience buoyancy in both, and the same other regions which experience stagnation in both.

We are now in a position to set out more formally the conditions that would need to be met before a region could be correctly categorized as an (upward) escalator region. They are:

1. That the region would attract to itself many young people at the start of their working lives; in particular, it would attract young people with promotion potential, such as those with qualifications, those seeking to gain such qualifications, and those who are most prepared to relocate themselves for the sake of personal advancement. This is stage one—stepping on the escalator.
2. That the region would provide the context within which these in-migrants, together with many of those born and brought up in the region, would achieve accelerated upward social mobility through movement within the region's labour and

housing markets. This is stage two—being taken up by the escalator. (Please note that although this paper comes close to talking about the region doing this or doing that, it is not the author's intention to indulge in spatial fetishism. Clearly the region does not itself cause outcomes; rather these outcomes arise from the location there of particular combinations of social relationships and processes.)

3. That the region would then lose through out-migration a significant proportion of those who had experienced this upward social mobility. These out-migrants would be in the middle to later stages of their working lives, or at or near to retirement. They would migrate partly to 'cash in' the assets gained during their social promotion in the escalator region. Some of these assets would be sold (for example, the expensive suburban or ex-urban house), others would 'stretch' further outside the escalator region due to lower living costs (for example, a nationally-negotiated salary, share income or a generous pension), while others would be drawn upon for the purpose of developing a new career (for example, the use of specialized skills, valuable contacts and management experience to set up in business on one's own). The product of the realization of these assets would be the establishment for the individual of a position of high social status and/or considerable economic security and influence in an environmentally-attractive non-escalator region. This is stage three—stepping off the escalator.

The metaphor of the escalator has certain distinct advantages in considering the connections between intra-generational social mobility and geographical mobility. Firstly, it emphasizes the youthfulness, low income, low status, single-person household character of the in-migration flows to global metropolitan cities, relative to the middle-aged, high income, high status, multi-person household character of the out-migration flows. Secondly, it stresses the importance of factors other than the personal attributes of the individual (in this case regional location) which contribute to that individual's life chances. Thirdly, it expresses, in a highly dynamic fashion, the social and political significance of the economic geography of a country. And finally, it asserts the crucial role of migration in social promotion. These advantages amount to nothing, however, unless it can be shown that certain regions (such as South East England) do indeed display the expected properties of an escalator region.

EVIDENCE REQUIRED TO ESTABLISH THAT THE SOUTH EAST IS AN ESCALATOR REGION

Evidence of a general link between social and geographical mobility

The first step in examining the specific connection between social and geographical mobility, implied by the notion of the South East region as an escalator region, is to discover whether or not a link between intra-generational social mobility and inter-regional migration can be shown to exist at a more general level. Considering how potentially important such a link is for an understanding of social change in contemporary Britain, it is surprising how little research effort has been devoted to it. Could it be that the lack of aggregate data on this subject has contributed to the absence of research interest? If this is so, then with the general availability of the results of the Longitudinal Study, there should now be a sudden increase in such research because the LS dataset is ideally suited to investigation of this relationship.

We can demonstrate that this is so using Tables 1, 2 and 3. Table 1 shows the relationships between inter-regional migration, social class and housing tenure. (For details of the social class categories used in this analysis see FIELDING, 1989.) At first glance this table may appear to tell us little more than we already know from analyses of the cross-sectional one-year migration data from the population census. Indeed the values in the third column probably seem familiar; they show that professional, technical and managerial employees (the service class) are highly inter-regionally mobile (194=94% above the average), while manual (blue collar) workers are highly immobile (55=45% below the average). The table also shows the high mobility of private sector (other) tenants, the near-average mobility of owner occupiers and the very low mobility of council tenants (that is, tenants in social housing). But the values in column four are rather different; these data exclude new entrants onto the labour market and suggest, through the significant reduction in the value for private tenants, that this tenure is a tenure of transition used by those who are in the early stages of their working lives. The really significant changes, however, arise with column five. Here the inter-regional migration rates are for those who were social class and housing tenure stayers, that is, those who were in the same class or tenure category in both 1971 and 1981. This is, therefore, a much truer picture of class- and tenure-specific mobility rates. It can be seen that the value for the self-employed and owners of small and medium-sized businesses (the *petite bourgeoisie*) has dropped sharply to the level of manual workers, indicating that people are fairly geographically mobile as they enter this class but very immobile once they are in it. The mobility rates

Table 1. *Inter-regional migration, social class and housing tenure: England and Wales, 1971–81*

Social class/housing tenure category	Class/tenure in 1981	%	In labour market in 1981	In labour market in 1971/81	In same class/tenure in 1971/81
Service class	45,988	21.1	194	188	222
Petite bourgeoisie	14,451	6.6	91	97	54
White collar	57,501	26.4	92	94	99
Blue collar	82,197	37.7	55	56	55
Unemployed	17,834	8.2	98	110	104
Total	217,971	100.0	100	100	100
Owner occupiers	137,669	63.2	111	117	129
Council tenants	58,364	26.8	42	41	27
Other tenants	21,938	10.1	182	145	115
Total	217,971	100.0	100	100	100

Notes: The social class categories are as follows:

Service class = professional, technical and managerial workers = SEGs 1, 2.2, 3, 4 and 5.1

Petite bourgeoisie = employers and self employed = SEGs 2.1, 12, 13 and 14

White collar proletariat = lower level non-manual employees = SEGs 5.2, 6 and 7

Blue collar proletariat = manual employees = SEGs 8, 9, 10, 11, 15 and 17

Please note that the data refer to men and women and to full-time and part-time employment.

The data refer to people who were in England and Wales at both dates. Columns 3, 4 and 5 are inter-regional migration rates expressed as ratios of the values for England and Wales (England and Wales = 100). 1.096% sample.

Source: OPCS Longitudinal Study (crown copyright reserved).

Table 2. *The association between inter-regional migration and changes in social class and housing tenure: England and Wales, 1971–81*

Social class in 1971	Social class in 1981					Total
	Service class	Petite bourgeoisie	White collar	Blue collar	Unemployed	
Service class	103	117	89	73	115	100
Petite bourgeoisie	185	69	161	100	190	100
White collar	165	163	77	77	157	100
Blue collar	209	168	136	75	133	100
Unemployed	215	104	113	79	70	100
Housing tenure in 1971	Housing tenure in 1981				Total	
	Owner occupiers	Council tenants	Other tenants			
Owner occupiers	94	121	232		100	
Council tenants	192	37	337		100	
Other tenants	141	67	63		100	

Notes: The data refer to people who were in the labour market in England and Wales at both dates. Inter-regional migration rates: England and Wales = 100. Standardized by social class and housing tenure in 1971.

Source: OPCS Longitudinal Study (crown copyright reserved).

of the service class are now very high (more than double the average), but the mobility of the unemployed remains stubbornly around the average, confounding expectations based upon standard economic theory. The council tenant stayers are quite remarkably immobile, and the private tenant stayers are now less mobile than owner occupiers. It is clear that these results require us to reconsider some of our ideas about class- and tenure-specific mobility rates. But it could reasonably be argued that these figures

still tell us almost nothing about the relationship between migration and social *mobility*. They only embellish what we already know about the class-specific nature of migration.

This could not be said, however, about the data in Table 2. Here the inter-regional migration rates (standardized by class of origin in 1971) are provided for all the possible transitions in the labour and housing markets. Each value in this table is calculated by multiplying by 100 the ratio of the percentage of

inter-regional migrants for each transition to the percentage of inter-regional migrants for the whole class. If there was no relationship between social mobility and geographical mobility, all the values in this table would approximate 100. As it is, there is a definite pattern discernible in the data. The values in the diagonals (103, 69, 77, 75, 70, 94, 37, 63) are, in every instance except one, below 100, while a clear majority of the values away from the diagonals are above 100. The significance of this finding can hardly be overstated; it means *that those who remained in the same class or housing tenure (the stayers) were less geographically mobile than the average for that class/tenure, while those who were inter-class or inter-tenure movers were more mobile than the average*. Thus social mobility and geographical mobility are positively related to one another; those who change their class locations are also likely to change their geographical locations.

Three particular features of this table deserve special mention: the first is the tendency for high inter-regional mobility values to coincide with entry into the target social categories, that is, the service class and owner occupation; the second is the tendency for similar high values to occur for transfers into transitional categories such as unemployment and other tenures; the third is the fact that the one case where a diagonal value is over 100 is for service class stayers. It is tempting to infer from this last fact that

geographical mobility is, in some way or another, a property of this class, perhaps even one of its defining characteristics (see the concluding remarks).

So far so good. But it is one thing to prove the existence of a relationship, quite another to demonstrate the importance of the relationship, or the nature and direction of the causal connections involved. Table 3 does not help us much with the direction of causality, but it does say a great deal about the relative importance of the association between social mobility and geographical mobility. The values in this table should be read from the top left to the bottom right—11.4% to 55.4%, and 18.3% to 57.5%. The top left hand value represents the proportion of those people in the labour market in 1971 who were not in the service class then, who had 'made it' into the service class by 1981. The service class is selected for special attention because of the privileged position it enjoys in the labour market with respect to occupational status, pay and job security. Table 3 shows that just 11.4% (or one-in-nine) of the total workforce gained access to the service class between 1971 and 1981. Those who were male, however, had a slightly higher chance of entering the service class (12.3%). Their chances were also improved if they came from owner occupier households in 1971. If they were male white collar workers in 1971 their chances improved to 31.7% (notice, incidentally, how gender achieves

Table 3. Interactions between inter-regional migration, social class, housing tenure, gender and region, as they affect entry to the service class: England and Wales, 1971–81

			Total		Inter-regional migrants only		
			Total	Males only	Total	Males only	
<i>In labour market in 1971</i>							
Total	{	England and Wales	Total	11.4	12.3	23.1	26.0
			Owner occupiers only	14.7	16.4	26.1	30.5
	{	South East only	Total	13.5	15.1	28.2	32.0
			Owner occupiers only	17.4	20.0	33.9	39.9
White collar only	{	England and Wales	Total	18.8	31.7	31.1	45.6
			Owner occupiers only	21.7	35.6	32.6	48.0
	{	South East only	Total	19.7	32.1	35.8	49.8
			Owner occupiers only	22.9	36.0	40.6	55.4
<i>Entries from education 1971-81</i>							
		England and Wales	Total	18.3	18.2	45.7	47.9
			Owner occupiers only	24.0	24.2	49.0	50.5
		South East only	Total	19.0	19.8	50.5	53.7
			Owner occupiers only	25.3	25.8	54.2	57.5

Notes: The data refer to people in England and Wales at both dates. A rate of entry into the service class is calculated by dividing the number of people entering the service class 1971–81 by the number of people in the category of origin in 1971. The rates of entry are therefore transition probabilities $\times 100$. Data for South East inter-regional migrants are for flows to the South East.

Sources: OPCS Longitudinal Study (crown copyright reserved).

major significance through its intersection with social class). But from the point of view of this paper, it is the values relating to inter-regional migration and to the South East region which take on a special importance. It can be seen that residence in the South East in 1971 enhances the chance of entry into the service class by several percentage points, but that the real increase derives from inter-regional migration, and especially from migration to the South East. Indeed, a male white collar worker living in owner occupation in 1971, who migrates to the South East had a better than one-in-two chance of gaining entry into the service class (55.4%). If the table had been extended to include all the circumstances which served to inhibit upward mobility into the service class, we would see that a female non-migrant blue collar worker living in council accommodation in 1971 had only a 3% chance of entering the service class. Thus a roughly twenty-fold difference exists between the most favoured and the least favoured people on the basis of this particular measure of life chances.

The lower part of Table 3 carries out a similar exercise for those who were in full-time education in 1971 but were in the labour market in 1981. The association of upward social mobility into the service class with inter-regional migration is equally as remarkably demonstrated here as in the values for those in the labour market at both dates.

To summarize, this sub-section began by providing new data on a familiar theme—the class- and tenure-specific nature (or selectivity) of migration. It proceeded to demonstrate that there is a positive relationship between change in class position and change in region of residence. It ended by showing how important inter-regional migration to the South East seems to be in the intersection of the many factors which combine to shape an individual's chances of social promotion to the service class of professional, technical and managerial workers.

Evidence of the South East region's net gain of (potentially upwardly mobile) young adults through inter-regional migration

The remarkable recent history of migration to and from the South East region is now beginning to be known and understood. Unpublished NHSCR data (available from the OPCS's Migration Statistics Unit) shows that the region was losing more than 30,000 people a year to the rest of the United Kingdom during the mid-1970s. By the early 1980s this had been turned into a small net gain of between 6,000 to 9,000 people a year. By 1985/86, the year for which age-specific data is presented here, this small net gain had become a small net loss. This was followed in the late 1980s by a sharp intensification of net loss, so that by 1988/89, the region was losing

55,000 people a year to the rest of the country. The curious fact about these changes in net gains and losses, however, is that they arose almost entirely as a result of changes in the rates of out-migration; in-migration was quite remarkably stable over the whole of this period. Seemingly untouched by a deep manufacturing recession in the Midlands, North and West in the early 1980s (which should have enlarged the flow) and by the house price inflation in the South East in the late 1980s (which should have stemmed the flow), young people continued to move to the South East—year in, year out.

NHSCR data for the age structure of migration flows to and from the South East are available for 1985/86. In that year the total net migration balance as a result of exchanges with other regions in the United Kingdom was -3,000, but the net balance for the three five-year age groups between 15 and 30 were +3,000, +24,000, and +8,000, producing an overall net gain of young adults of +35,000. Thus the first requirement of our escalator region concept is fully met; the South East region is a major net gainer of people who are at the stage of entering the labour market, or are in the very earliest stages of their careers. This is confirmed by Fig. 1 which shows the rates of net flow of people aged 20 to 24 to the South East region. These rates of flow are measured using migration 'velocities'. A migration velocity is a

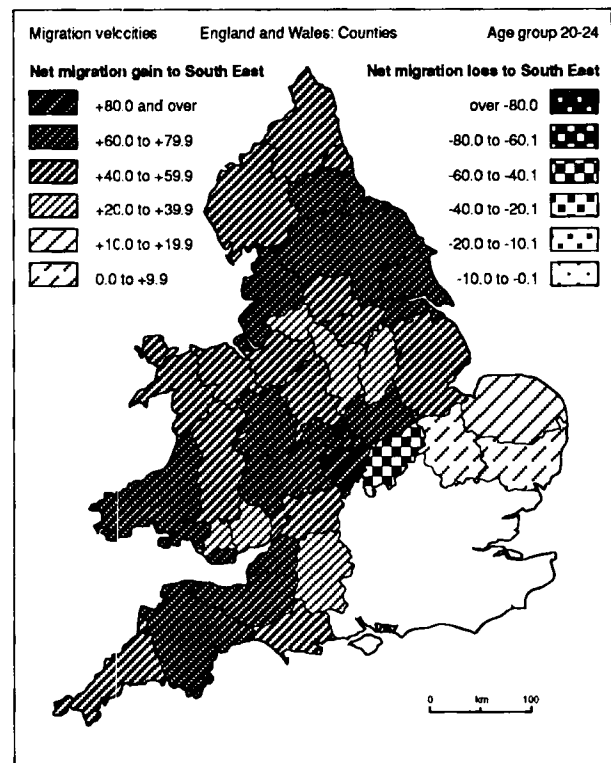


Fig. 1. Rates of net migration flow to the South East region of people aged 20-24: 1985/86

Source: NHSCR (OPCS copyright reserved).

migration flow standardized for the population sizes at both origin and destination locations. It is calculated by dividing the migration flow by the product of the populations origin and destination, thus:

$$mv = kM_{ij}/P_iP_j$$

where: mv = migration velocity

M = migration flow

i = origin region

j = destination region

k = scaling factor to obtain whole number values

P = population

The first point to make about Fig. 1 is that all the values except one are positive. This indicates that the South East is a net gainer of young people from every county in England and Wales (except Northamptonshire). The second point to note is that there are broad regional differences in rates of net flow to the South East; the rates of flow are particularly high from the southwest peninsula, from the South and West Midlands and from parts of the North. Finally, though this is not visible in the map pattern, there is a strong bias in the direction of the rates of net gain to the South East being higher for origin counties with a university over those without a university. In the case of the twenty-two counties with a university, seventeen had migration velocities to the South East exceeding fifty, and only five had migration velocities of under fifty; the equivalent figures for the nineteen counties without a university were six with over fifty, and thirteen with under fifty.

This last finding is interesting in that it hints at the possibility that a fair proportion of those entering the South East in their early twenties are the graduates from provincial universities, a result which would

conform very closely to expectations based upon the notion of an escalator region. Hints are not enough, however. What is needed is direct evidence on the social composition of the migration stream from the rest of the country to the South East region. This cannot come from the NHSCR, but it can be provided by the LS, though unfortunately at the moment only for the decade 1979–81, and only for flows from England and Wales. Table 4 is a synthesis of the LS data on the social composition of the migration stream from the regions of England and Wales to the South East region. The location quotients were calculated as follows: the percentage that each social class/category transition accounted for in the flow to the South East was expressed as a ratio of the equivalent percentage for all inter-regional migrations in England and Wales. Where the percentages were the same, the location quotient equals 1.00; a value of 2.00 would mean that the particular transition was twice as important in the flow to the South East as in all inter-regional migration, a value of 0.50 would mean that the transition was only half as important in the flow to the South East as in all inter-regional migration.

Table 4 provides direct evidence, from a totally new perspective, of the bias towards young people in the flow of migrants to the South East, and also an indication that job prospects might well be important to those migrants. The row and column totals should be examined first. The values in the final column refer to the importance of particular social origins in the migration flow to the South East. It can be seen that only two values exceed 1.00; the highest is for those leaving full time education (24% above the average), and the other is for those leaving unemployment. The destination location quotients on the bottom row are equally informative. Notice not only that the service class heads the list of destinations, followed closely by white collar employment but

Table 4. *The social composition of migration flows to the South East region from elsewhere in England and Wales, 1971–81: dyadic location quotients*

Social class in 1971	Social class in 1981							
	Service class	Petite bourgeoisie	White collar	Blue collar	Unemployed	Total in labour market	Retired	Other
Service class	1.01	0.43	1.02	0.89	0.92	0.97	0.53	0.68
Petite bourgeoisie	0.90	0.57	0.79	0.83	0.31	0.67	0.69	0.81
White collar	1.07	0.53	0.98	0.70	0.59	0.93	0.40	0.71
Blue collar	1.06	0.53	1.18	0.79	0.74	0.84	0.49	0.69
Unemployed	1.41	1.11	0.95	1.21	0.80	1.12	1.21	1.05
Total in labour market	1.04	0.53	1.02	0.81	0.71	0.91	0.52	0.72
Education	1.63	0.90	1.65	1.15	1.07	1.50	1.00	0.98
Other	1.14	0.61	1.07	0.79	0.85	0.97	0.89	0.81
Total	1.28	0.59	1.27	0.90	0.87	1.12	0.65	0.88

Notes: A location quotient of 1.00 means that the transition in question is equally as important in the flows to the South East as it is for all inter-regional migrants in England and Wales. This table excludes deaths and 'not found'.

Source: Longitudinal Study (crown copyright reserved).

that, unlike the equivalent origin location quotient, that for the total in the labour market is well above 1.00, emphasizing the significance of job opportunities for migrants to the South East. As for the individual transitions, those for transfers from education to the service class, and from education to white collar work, stand out as being especially important.

The LS can be used in another way to examine this question of the nature of the in-migration stream to the South East. If one takes the number of people who make the transition from education to the professions among the in-migrants to the South East and subtracts the numbers who make the same transition among the out-migrants from the South East, one obtains a net figure. This can then be expressed as a net rate by dividing it by the number of professionals in the region. The result of this calculation is a rate of net gain to the South East region of +46.0 per 1,000 for professionals, and a net gain of +16.7 per 1,000 for managers. Clearly, the flow to the South East is strongly biased towards those leaving education and entering service class jobs.

To summarize, evidence from both the NHSCR and LS datasets supports the view that the South East attracts a more than proportional share of upwardly mobile young adults through inter-regional migration. The fact that much of the most telling information comes from the LS and refers to the 1971–81 period suggests that, contrary to popular belief, the phenomenon of the London-based upwardly mobile young professional was by no means a product of the ‘Thatcher revolution’ of the 1980s.

Evidence of accelerated social promotion in the South East

There is ample evidence in the material discussed above and in the data presented in Table 3 that the migrants to the South East tend to benefit from accelerated social promotion. This is interesting and important, but it is not sufficient to justify confidence in the idea that the South East is an escalator region. After all, the inter-regional in-migrants are a fairly small minority in the South East’s labour market; what we need to know is whether or not the majority of those in the labour market, that is to say the non-migrants, are enjoying the benefits of accelerated social promotion. Only then can we conceive of our in-migrants being carried aloft by the deep-rooted social promotion properties of the region.

As Figs. 2 to 5 show, the LS is ideally suited to this task. In each of these figures, the percentages leaving a particular origin social category to enter a particular destination social category in each region are expressed as a ratio of the equivalent percentage for the whole population of England and Wales. A value above 1.00 indicates a faster transfer than the average, a value below 1.00 indicates a slower transfer than the

average. In Fig. 2, the transition from full-time education to an employment which entails managerial responsibilities is shown to be 45% more frequent in the South East than in England and Wales as a whole. Indeed, it is only the South East region which has a location quotient value in excess of 1.00, and the rates of promotion to managerial positions are especially low in Wales and in the North.

The spatial pattern for promotion from education into the professions is interestingly different. The South East is again pre-eminent but this time to a lesser degree, and the value for Wales is close to the England and Wales average. This difference for Wales is highly significant in that it shows that there is a spatial or regional dimension to the three main alternative paths to promotion to middle class occupational status—by means of credentials (‘professionals’), through the acquisition of organizational skills (managers), and through entrepreneurial ability (petite bourgeoisie): for the Welsh it seems that the route through formal qualifications is particularly important. Figs. 4 and 5 show the equivalent transitions into managerial and professional occupations, but this time from working class origins instead of education. Once again, the South East reveals unusually high rates of social promotion, though in the case of the working class entries into the professions, the rates for the South West and Wales also exceed 1.00.

To summarize, LS data on regional differences in rates of social promotion into the professional and managerial middle classes show the pre-eminence of the South East region as the region *par excellence* of upward social mobility.

Evidence of the South East region's net loss of older middle class people through inter-regional migration

To complete the picture of the South East as an escalator region we need to be able to show that it is a net loser of mid-career and older middle class people. The NHSCR can help again here. Figs. 6 and 7 show the patterns of net migration to the South East for those in their forties, and those in their sixties. The pattern for those in their sixties is probably no great surprise. All the values are negative except for Manchester and Birmingham, indicating that the South East region is a net loser of older people to all but two of the counties in England and Wales (the total net loss in 1985/86 was –13,000). But the rates of net loss vary greatly; they are highest to the more rural regions of southern and eastern England (and rural mid-Wales), and lowest to the urban industrial regions of the North and West. Thus people at or around the age of retirement tend to leave the London metropolitan city region to live in areas characterized by free-standing provincial cities, small market towns and villages, located in the southern half of the country.

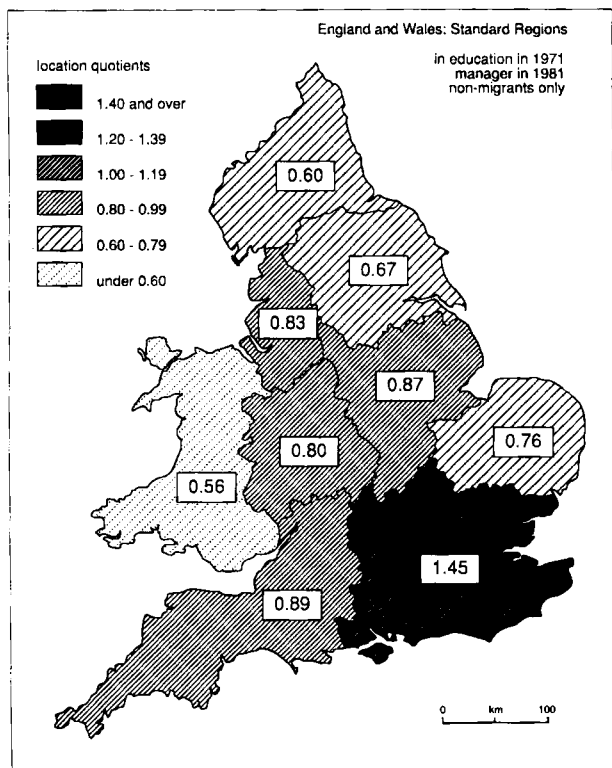


Fig. 2. The transition from full-time education in 1971 to a managerial occupation in 1981
Source: OPCS Longitudinal Survey (crown copyright reserved).

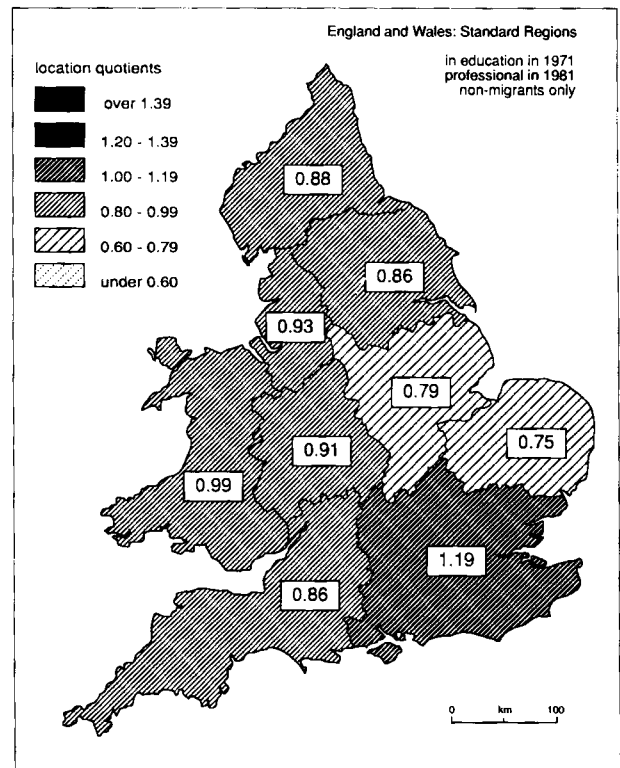


Fig. 3. The transition from full-time education in 1971 to a professional occupation in 1981
Source: OPCS Longitudinal Survey (crown copyright reserved).

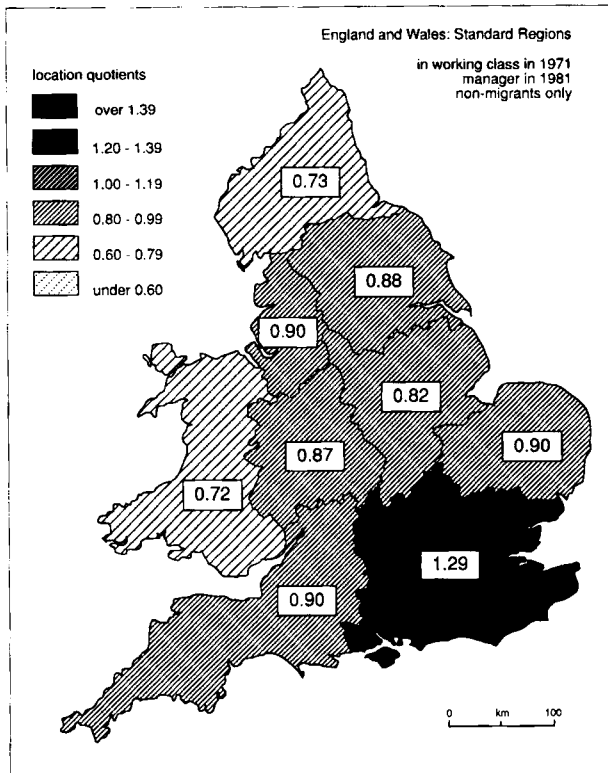


Fig. 4. The transition from a working class occupation in 1971 to a managerial occupation in 1981
Source: OPCS Longitudinal Survey (crown copyright reserved).

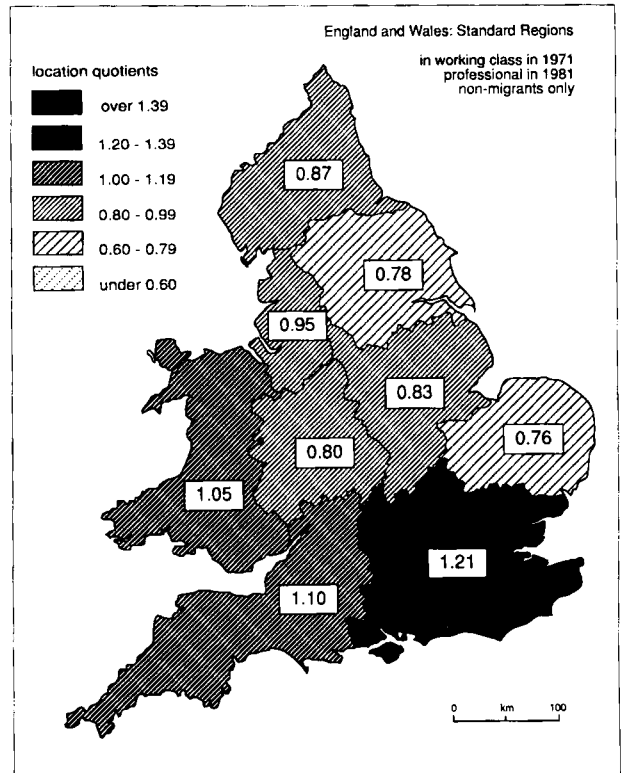


Fig. 5. The transition from a working class occupation in 1971 to a professional occupation in 1981
Source: OPCS Longitudinal Survey (crown copyright reserved).

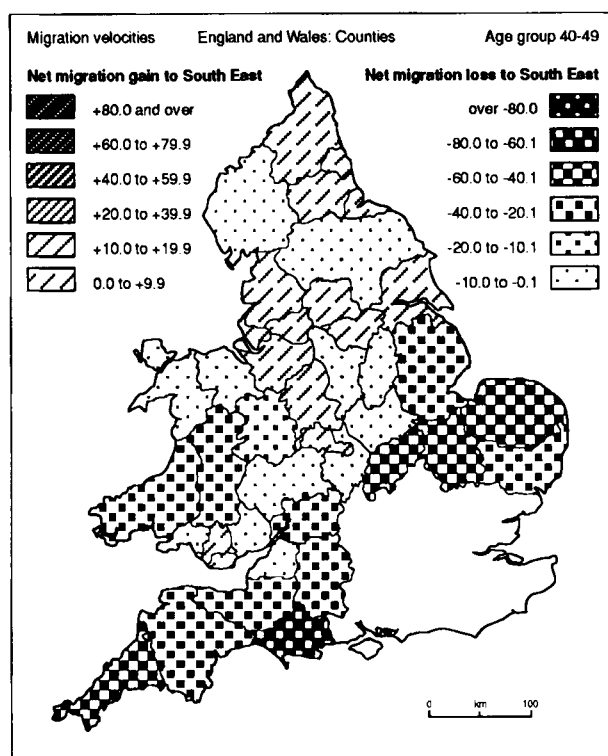


Fig. 6. Rates of net migration flow to the South East region of people aged 40-49: 1985/6

Source: NHSCR (OPCS copyright reserved).

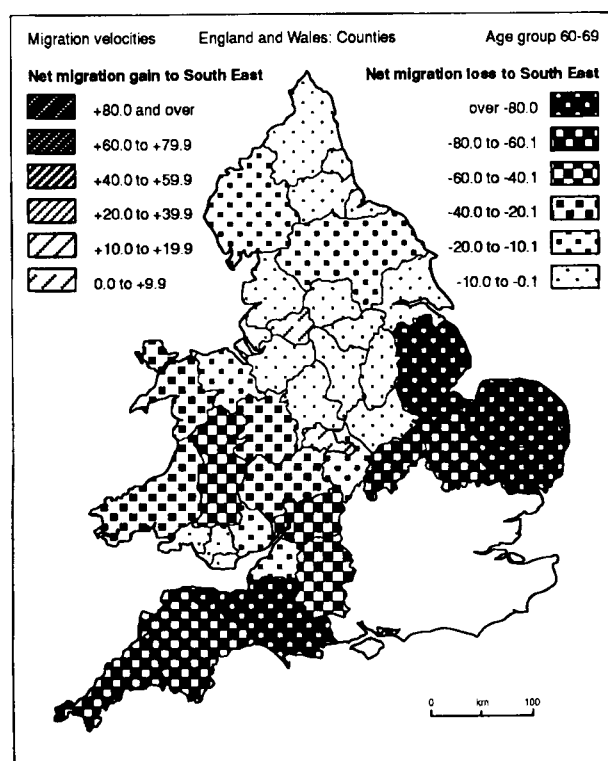


Fig. 7. Rates of net migration flow to the South East region of people aged 60-69: 1985/6

Source: NHSCR (OPCS copyright reserved).

The remarkable feature of the map pattern for the net migration flows of those in their forties, is how similar it is to that of those in their sixties, and how dissimilar it is to that of people in their twenties (see Fig. 1). Once again, the dominant characteristic is that the values are mostly negative, indicating net flow from the South East (totalling -4,000 in 1985/86). Only urban industrial areas in the Midlands and North (plus a small part of south Wales) show positive values, and then the rates are extremely low. The rates of net outflow from the South East are particularly high to East Anglia and the South West, but also show high values for rural mid-Wales. Thus, long before leaving the labour market, many people are leaving the South East region to live in environmentally attractive areas in southern Britain.

Who are these mid-career out-migrants from the South East? To answer this question we need to turn once again to the LS. Analyses of the social compositions of the flows of migrants to and from the South East of those who were in the labour market in both 1971 and 1981, show that the South East is a major net loser of mid-career service class members. The net rate for professionals is -15.0 per 1,000, while that for managers is -10.5 per 1,000. This finding sits very uncomfortably with the popular idea of a 'drift to the south' of mid-career managers and professionals; in fact service class stayers on balance migrate away from the South East. As the first value in Table 6 shows, the region lost 25,000 service class stayers in the 1971-81 period: -273(100/1.096). *The South East region is a net exporter of its qualified and experienced service class population.*

This would be an interesting result in itself. But the LS can be used, as before, to show all the social class transitions which accompany out-migration from the South East region, and not just those of the social class stayers. These are synthesized in Table 5. Once again, it is best to concentrate attention initially on the row and column totals. The final column shows the social class origins of the out-migrants. It can be seen that there is a bias towards those coming from the labour market, and especially from white collar and service class occupations. The category 'other' is also important (this indicates full time housewives and those who make the transitions education-to-education and retired-to-retired). Those entering the labour market either from education or from unemployment are particularly poorly-represented in this migration stream. The bottom row shows the destination social categories. Two categories are of outstanding importance; the first is retirement which is 39% more important in this flow than in all inter-regional migrations, and the second is the petite bourgeoisie. This latter value probably reflects two things: firstly, the rather older average age of the migrants from the South East region to the rest of England and Wales; and secondly, the high

Table 5. *The social composition of migration flows from the South East region to elsewhere in England and Wales, 1971–81: dyadic location quotients*

Social class in 1971	Social class in 1981							
	Service class	Petite bourgeoisie	White collar	Blue collar	Unemployed	Total in labour market	Retired	Other
Service class	1.04	1.40	1.16	1.16	1.19	1.08	1.49	1.26
Petite bourgeoisie	0.86	1.34	1.29	0.96	1.08	1.13	1.17	1.09
White collar	0.94	1.40	1.07	1.02	1.37	1.07	1.86	1.29
Blue collar	0.95	1.09	0.88	0.99	1.10	0.99	1.47	0.97
Unemployed	0.62	0.78	1.05	0.68	0.96	0.79	0.79	0.78
Total in labour market	1.00	1.27	1.06	0.99	1.14	1.04	1.53	1.19
Education	0.58	1.24	0.68	0.85	0.81	0.68	0.62	0.95
Other	0.88	1.22	0.98	1.15	0.94	1.02	1.15	1.14
Total	0.82	1.26	0.90	0.97	0.99	0.91	1.39	1.05

Notes: A location quotient of 1.00 = same as all inter-regional migrants in England and Wales. This table excludes deaths and 'not found'.
Source: OPCS Longitudinal Study (crown copyright reserved).

Table 6. *Net effect on the South East region of the social compositions of the in-migration and out-migration flows, 1971–81: sample numbers*

Net effect on social class in South East	Of exchanges with:							
	Service class	Petite bourgeoisie	White collar	Blue collar	Unemployed	Total in labour market	Education/retired	Other
Service class	-273	-68	+94	+30	-14	-231	+938	-88
Petite bourgeoisie	-8	-60	+2	+9	-7	-64	-15	-19
White collar	-183	-73	-136	-15	-62	-469	+401	-371
Blue collar	-90	-77	-36	-206	-86	-495	+34	-29
Unemployed	+6	-5	+1	+31	-10	+23	+136	+1
Total in labour market	-548	-283	-75	-151	-179	-1,236	+1,494	-506
Education/retired	-524	-38	-334	-225	-139	-1,260	+1	-1,861
Other	-56	-34	-42	-149	-21	-302	+1,191	-543
Total	-1,128	-355	-451	-525	-339	-2,798	+2,686	-2,910

Notes: 1.096% sample. This table excludes deaths and 'not found'.
Source: OPCS Longitudinal Study (crown copyright reserved).

propensity for service class and white collar employees to switch into self employment and the ownership of small and medium-sized businesses as they move away from the South East. This can be seen in the individual values, where apart from the transitions into retirement, the transfers from the service class and the white collar workers into the petite bourgeoisie produce the highest location quotients in the whole table (1.40).

To summarize, the NHSCR and LS datasets provide information which supports the view that many people 'step off' the escalator during the later stages of their middle class careers, or at or close to retirement. They do so by migrating to areas of 'urbanized countryside' located in southern Britain (especially in East Anglia and the South West), and while many transfer into retirement, others continue in the same line of work that they did in the South East, and yet others start new careers, notably by setting up in business on their own.

This material on out-migration from the South

East completes the picture. Standing back from the detail, it can be seen that the conditions set in section one have been met; the evidence fully supports the assertion that the South East region displays all the characteristics required of an escalator region.

QUALIFICATIONS TO THE VIEW THAT THE SOUTH EAST IS AN ESCALATOR REGION

It is tempting to stop the analysis at this point. But to do so would involve leaving the impression that the escalator concept copes well with all aspects of migration to and from South East England. This is not the case. Our final empirical section, therefore, addresses certain problems with the escalator region concept as it is applied to the South East region and attempts, in so doing, to go beyond it in order to make contact with the full complexity of the region's migration experience. Three specific sources of complexity are discussed. The first is the important role

of the South East region in international migration; the second is the effect of the size and diversity of the region's labour and housing markets on its migration experience; and the third is the awkward fact that geographical mobility is not always associated with social promotion, but in certain instances, with social demotion.

These complexities are revealed in part through a more detailed analysis of the social and geographical origins of managers and professionals. In Figs. 8 and 9, the LS has been used to trace these origins for each region in England and Wales. In these figures the sizes of the circles are proportional to the sizes of the regional labour markets, and the thicknesses of the spokes are proportional to the importance of that particular flow for that occupation in England and Wales as a whole. The important feature is the length of the spoke in relation to the circumference. The circumference of the circle represents a location quotient of 1.00, so where the spoke falls short of the circumference that flow is less important than the average, where it breaks through the circumference it is more important than the average. The position of the

spoke defines the source of the flow into the occupation. Those on the 'east' side are non-migrants, and recruitment is occurring within the region; those on the 'west' side are in-migrants and recruitment is taking place from other regions.

We can begin by examining the South East region in Figs. 8 and 9. By far the highest location quotient in both cases is for immigrants. Thus, the most distinctive feature of the recruitment of managers and professionals in the South East is the tendency for them to be obtained from outside England and Wales. Clearly, this represents a very important qualification to the picture outlined above; the South East's service class is not just formed *in situ*, or through inter-regional in-migration, but also through migration from beyond the boundaries of England and Wales, mostly international migration. This has considerable significance for class consciousness and for class-based political behaviour. But for our purposes it carries another meaning; insofar as the service class positions in the South East are filled by international in-migrants, they are not filled by in-migrants within Britain, thus reducing the

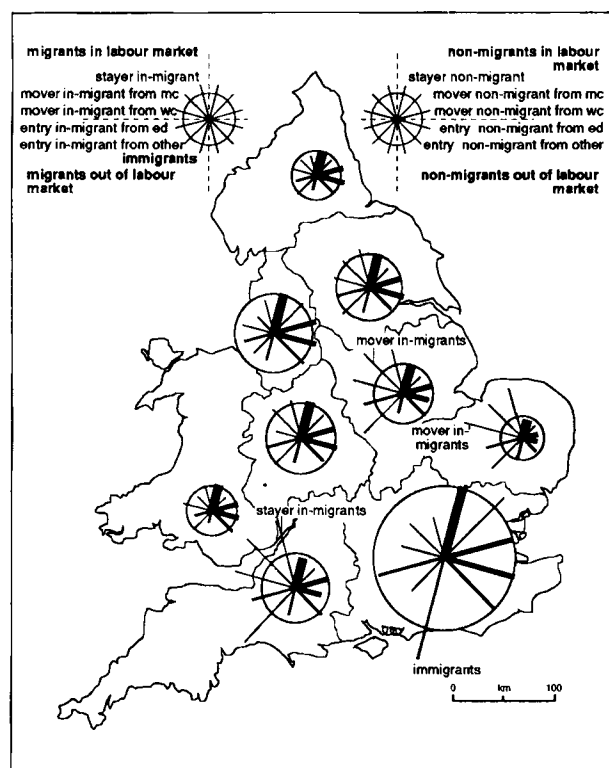


Fig. 8. The social and geographical origins in 1971 of those who were managers in 1981

Note: England and Wales: standard regions. The distance from the centre of the circle to its circumference = a location quotient of 1.0; ed = education; mc = middle class; wc = working class.

Source: OPCS Longitudinal Survey (crown copyright reserved).

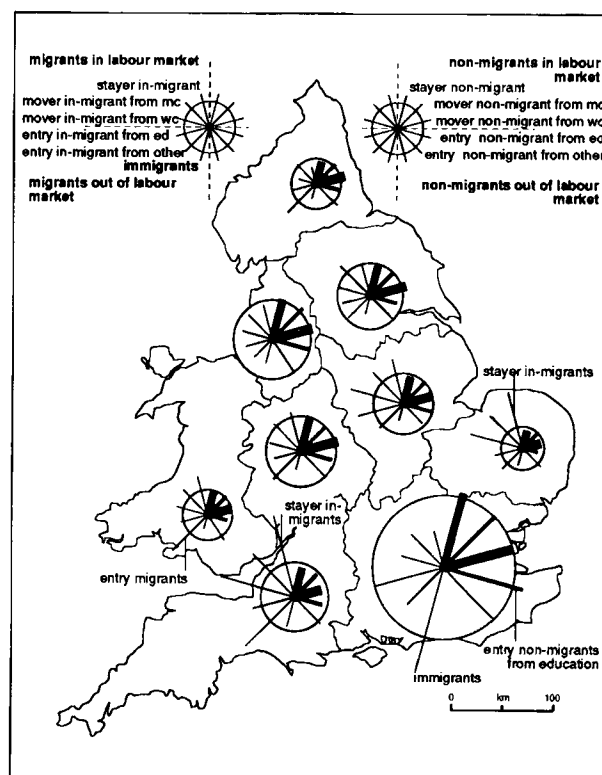


Fig. 9. The social and geographical origins in 1971 of those who were professionals in 1981

Note: England and Wales: standard regions. The distance from the centre of the circle to its circumference = a location quotient of 1.0; ed = education; mc = middle class; wc = working class.

Source: OPCS Longitudinal Survey (crown copyright reserved).

opportunities for the social escalator to work in the manner described above. The prospect of heightened international intra-European migration of professionals, technicians and managers after 1992 contributes to the significance of this point.

The most noticeable feature of the South East region's location quotients in Figs. 8 and 9, however, is the predominance of very low values for in-migration; even the values for those coming from education elsewhere in England and Wales barely touch the circumference of the circle. The South East region, therefore, largely recruits its service class internally, from within the region, rather than resorting to inter-regional in-migrants. This clashes sharply with the emphasis on the in-migration of young people expressed in the escalator region concept. In contrast, the regions around the South East which have much smaller labour markets show very high location quotients for their recruitment from outside the region. Clearly, there is a size effect at work here. The London metropolitan city region is so large and diverse, so dense and rich in employment and housing opportunities, that a vast majority of labour and housing market shifts are internalized within the region. Conversely, the smaller regions are more 'open'; lower density and less variety of opportunities implies that a larger proportion of labour and housing market moves will result in a migration across the regional boundary. Of course, in addition to these reasons there are specific factors which might be expected to contribute to the low migration turnover of the South East region. They include: (1) the fact that it is difficult for dual career households to satisfy the job aspirations of both partners when a migration from the South East is undertaken; (2) more generally, a fear of a loss of position in either or both the labour and housing markets consequent upon out-migration from the South East; and (3) problems encountered by those outside the South East in gaining access to the South East's labour market due to the very high cost of housing in London and the South East.

The final qualification to the escalator region concept is fundamental. Until now the whole emphasis of this paper has been on the manner in which geographical mobility can be used to improve one's social standing. Undoubtedly, this is the dominant aspect of inter-regional migration and intra-generational social mobility in contemporary Britain. But people do not become migrants by one route alone, and while many choose to migrate to better themselves, others are transferred by their employers, and yet others have migration forced upon them, perhaps as a result of breakdown in a family relationship or as a result of redundancy. That downward social mobility might accompany inter-regional migration has already been indicated by the values in Fig. 2 where high migration rates were found for transi-

tions into unemployment and from owner occupation into council tenancy. The very size and diversity of the South East's labour/housing market discussed above, and the relative ease with which one can achieve anonymity there, makes it a likely destination for many of those seeking work, shelter or new social relationships, not from a position of strength but from a position of weakness. This is suggested by the data in Table 6, which incidentally, serves to summarize much of what has been said before in this paper. The final column of the table shows that the only two groups within the labour market to gain from inter-regional migration were the service class by 56,000 (+619[100/1.096]) and the unemployed by 15,000 (+160[100/1.096]). It should be remembered, however, that 1981 was a recession year and a time when a region in receipt of many young adult in-migrants would be likely to see a net gain in the number of its unemployed population through migration. Nevertheless, it remains the case that between 1971 and 1981 the South East region gained through migration at both ends of the social spectrum; or put another way, inter-regional migration during that period served not only to enlarge the South East's service class but also to enhance the degree of social polarization within the region.

To summarize, the notion of the South East as an escalator region is helpful, but rather too simplistic. While it encompasses many very important features of the migration and social change characteristics of the region, other equally important relationships and processes are outside its remit. As our servant, the escalator metaphor can be usefully provocative, but let it become master of the way we conceive the social and demographic relationships linking the South East region to the rest of the country, and much that is important will be ignored.

CONCLUDING REMARKS: CLASS AND REGION, SOCIETY AND SPACE

We have seen that regional context is extremely important in any understanding of the way in which individuals come to occupy specific class locations. The South East region, in particular, has been seen to be a kind of escalator region which not only promotes its own residents faster than other regions, but also attracts young educated people from elsewhere, promotes them and then sends them off again to other areas.

However, this is not the only, or arguably even the most important, link between region and class formation. Embedded in the very notion of a middle class person is the expectation that the relationship of that individual with the place or region of residence will be qualitatively different from that of a working class person. Each of the three paths leading to middle class membership (credentials to pro-

professionals, organizational experience to managers, and entrepreneurial skill to petite bourgeoisie) requires knowledge of, and ability to handle, non-locally based information, codes, rules, and systems of thought and action. With that 'cultural capital' also comes a certain social confidence. Information and experience which is to a high degree locally-rooted is, in the increasingly spatially interdependent world in which we live, totally inadequate as a basis for responsibility in employment or success as an independent economic agent.

The multi-locational character of middle class lifestyles and life histories is manifested in many ways. Many members of the middle class have had their horizons spatially extended by higher education, which in Britain usually implies residence in another region. They have often seen their careers develop through relocation from one area to another, and they tend to form households with partners from regions other than those in which they were themselves brought up. The de-localization of middle class biographies is reflected in the sphere of consumption, where foreign food and clothes, second homes and leisure travel figure prominently.

In addition to the middle classes being shaped by the regions in which they are formed, and to their partial characterization by their own often rather tenuous links with the regions in which they currently reside, the middle classes themselves serve to shape regions by the strength of their presence and

through the character of their work and home lives. In this way, South East England (despite its heterogeneity and the persistence of the 'south-south' divide) is stereotypically a service class region; its economy and culture are stamped by the strong presence of its stable yet cosmopolitan managerial and professional middle classes. It is, perhaps, the nearest we get in Britain to a 'non-place urban realm', a spatially extended zone of almost formless urban development, the product of a service sector economy, of high levels of home and car ownership, and of much prosperity, personal mobility and privatism. It may be an escalator region, but many would probably argue that it is also less 'place-full' and more banal than the regions of northern and western Britain with their strong local cultural identities and region-specific agricultural and industrial histories.

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